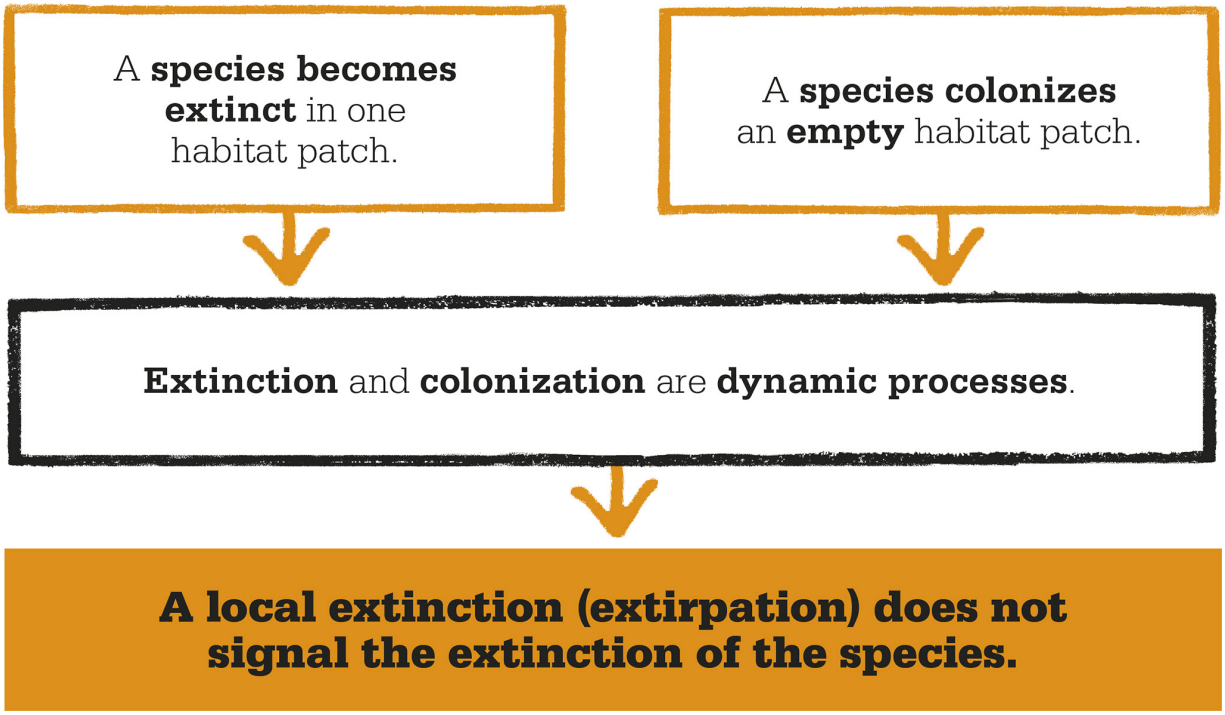
Since then, its use has expanded to cover any species broken up into local populations in fragmented habitats, both on land and in the oceans.

A particular species of bird, for instance, may be found in separate populations in a lowland forest, in mountain woodlands, and various other places. The species is like a family whose members have moved to different cities yet are still related. The combined effect of many populations may boost the long-term survival of the species.



Read accessible description

Apart but together

A crucial aspect of metapopulation theory is the level of interaction between the separate local populations. If the level is high, it is not considered to be a metapopulation—all the local groups are part of one big population. In a metapopulation contact between the various local groups is limited, and they remain partly cut off in their own local habitat or "patch." Yet there has to be at least some interaction. It may be just a single brave or outcast